Week 10 Teacher Guide: Apostolic Appointment: Where Doctrinal Authority Comes From

The Obedience of Faith, Week 10 of 12. Opens Unit IV (God's House).

Companion to Week10-ApostolicAppointment.pptx.

Scripture from the NET Bible.

Aim: Establish that teaching authority in the church is *conferred* through the apostolic deposit, not *generated* by gifting, sincerity, results, or cultural trajectory.

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves holding one distinction: *authority is conferred, not generated*, and understanding that this week is deliberately *upstream* of the roles question. We are not yet arguing about who may do what in the assembly (that's next week). We are answering the prior question of where teaching authority *comes from at all*. If the class grasps "gifting is given to the whole body; authority is conferred by the apostolic word," next week's harder conversation becomes far calmer, because the framework is already in place. Resist letting this week collapse into next week's debate.

Read this first: the tone and fairness mandate. Weeks 10 and 11 are the two genuinely contested lessons in the course, and this is where your credibility as a fair teacher is won or lost. A mixed adult class will contain people across the spectrum on church order, and some will arrive braced for a fight or a lecture. Three commitments will keep the room:

1. **Name the contest openly.** Say in the first minute that faithful Christians who love the same Bible disagree here, and that you'll handle it as Bereans: eager *and* examining, testing even the teacher (Week 5's explicit permission; invoke it by name).
2. **Steelman every opposing view.** When you present the alternatives (slide 2) and the trajectory objection (slide 5), state them at *full strength* and concede what's true in them. A teacher who caricatures the other side teaches the class to do the same and forfeits trust. The deck is built to model this: the trajectory slide literally says "state it at full strength."
3. **Distinguish structure from people.** You are analyzing where authority is *located*, not smearing the sincerity or godliness of anyone who located it differently. Many in the historical survey were genuine, fruitful believers. Say so.

Where this sits in the arc: Unit III (Testing) just closed. Unit IV asks how God's house is ordered. This week is the *foundational principle* (authority's source); next week is the *application* (roles in the assembly). Week 12 then moves to the household and commission. The course's whole method ("read like a Berean, test the teacher") was in a real sense building toward the class's ability to handle *these two weeks* charitably.

Presentation

Segment 1: One Question Underneath (0:00–10:00 · Slide 2)

Open with the tone-set (above), then narrow to the prior question.

The distinction (first click). Before "who may do what," there's a question underneath it: where does teaching authority in the church *come from*? There are only two possible answers. It is **conferred**: delivered, handed down, appointed, received from outside the person. Or it is **generated**: produced by something *in* the person or the moment. This single distinction is the whole lecture; make sure it lands before you show the table.

The table (second click, shown whole). Four movements across four centuries, each relocating authority to something *generated*:

- **Montanists** (2nd c.): direct revelation; "the Spirit is speaking new things now," through their prophets and prophetesses, overriding ordinary order.
- **Quakers** (17th c.): the inner light speaks through whomever it chooses; ordained office is not the channel.
- **Revivalism** (19th c.): demonstrated fruit; "look how God is manifestly using them" (Phoebe Palmer's argument for women's ministry rested here).
- **Modern scholarship** (20th c.): reconstructed cultural background, or a redemptive trajectory the text is moving along.

The right-hand column shows they are all *the same move* despite radically different vocabularies and eras: authority pulled from conferral toward self-generation. **Walk this fairly**: some of these people were sincere, sacrificial believers, and you should say so aloud. You are naming a structural pattern, not passing judgment on souls.

The pattern named (third click). Four centuries, four vocabularies, one move: authority relocated *from* appointment *to* something claimable without it: revelation, fruit, insight, progress. And the Week 3 callback: the question was never "were they sincere?" (sincerity was Unit I's dismissed test) but "is that where the New Testament *locates* authority?" Location, not sincerity, is the whole issue.

Transition: "Paul answers this question; remarkably, he answers it in the very passage people cite *for* spiritual gifts."

Segment 2: Paul Closes the Door (10:00–22:00 · Slide 3)

The setting (first click). This is the argument's backbone, so establish it firmly: 1 Corinthians 12–14 is *the* spiritual-gifts passage in the New Testament: tongues, prophecy, the Spirit's manifestations, "eagerly desire the greater gifts." This is not an anti-charismatic corner of Scripture; it's the most pro-gifts passage there is. And *right there*, Paul writes what comes next.

1 Corinthians 14:37–38 (second click). "If anyone considers himself a prophet or spiritual person, he should acknowledge that what I write to you is the Lord's command. If someone does not recognize this, he is not recognized." Read it slowly. "The Lord's *command*": apostolic writing carries the authority of divine command.

Whom Paul names (third click): the decisive observation. He does not aim this at skeptics or troublemakers. He names *prophets* and *spiritual people* (the two most impressive spiritual credentials available in that congregation) and subordinates *both* to what he writes. Crucially: **he does not deny they have gifts.** The Corinthian gifts were real; Paul spent two chapters regulating rather than denying them. What he denies is that gifts *adjudicate order*. Gift and office are different things, a distinction the early church kept precisely (next slide). Someone can genuinely have the Spirit's gifting and still not hold the authority to set the church's order; those are two separate questions.

The sanction and application (fourth click). Verse 38 attaches teeth: refusing to recognize apostolic authority is itself disqualifying ("he is not recognized"). So every claim that *bypasses* the apostolic word ("the Spirit told me," "look at the fruit," or "we've grown past this") runs into the wall Paul built *here, inside the gifts chapter itself*. That placement is the entire force of the argument: Paul isn't suspicious of the Spirit; he's telling Spirit-filled people that their gifting doesn't override his written instruction. Land it: gifting is given to the whole body; authority is conferred by the apostolic word.

Transition: "So if authority is conferred, *how* is it conferred? Paul shows us a chain."

Segment 3: Deposit and Handoff (22:00–34:00 · Slide 4)

The four texts (first click). The New Testament pictures authority as a *deposit passed down a chain*:

- **Appointed, not attained**: "for this I was appointed a preacher and apostle" (1 Tim 2:7). Paul's own authority was *given* to him, not achieved by him.
- **Traditions delivered and held**: "maintain the traditions just as I passed them on to you" (1 Cor 11:2). Transmitted property.
- **Entrusted to teach others**: "what you heard from me… entrust to faithful people who will be competent to teach others" (2 Tim 2:2).
- **Once for all entrusted**: "the faith that was once for all entrusted to the saints" (Jude 3).

Deposit → handoff, not discovery (second click). Highlight 2 Timothy 2:2: *four generations in one verse*: Paul → Timothy → faithful people → others. It's a relay, and the baton is received and passed, never invented mid-race. Authority travels by handoff; it doesn't well up from a spring inside the runner.

The early-church question (third click). The sub-apostolic church kept exactly this question: not "who has the gift?" but "who was appointed?" **Origen** concedes women may have the genuine prophetic gift and *still* restricts the venue in which it's exercised: gift affirmed, office distinguished. **Hippolytus** ties ordination to *liturgical function*: hands are laid on those with a governing role, not on everyone who has a gift. **Handle this evidence carefully and honestly:** these are historical witnesses to how the early church *read* the apostolic pattern: valuable as evidence of early practice, but not themselves inspired proof texts. Cite them as "here's how the generation after the apostles understood this," not as Scripture. (And note their limits fairly: the patristic evidence is real but geographically narrow, and these are prescriptive texts.)

The obedience-of-faith tie (fourth click). This is why the course's title phrase fits here: the whole apostleship exists "to bring about the obedience of faith" (Rom 1:5). The apostolic word is the *conferring* authority, and *receiving* it rather than generating a rival authority from gifting or fruit, is itself an act of the obedience of faith.

Transition: "One serious objection remains, and it deserves an honest hearing: the trajectory argument."

Segment 4: The Trajectory Argument, and Why It Inverts (34:00–42:00 · Slide 5)

This segment is where fairness earns the room. Do not skip it or soft-pedal the objection.

State the objection at full strength (first click). "Scripture regulated slavery without ever condemning it. The church eventually moved past slavery, recognizing the trajectory of Scripture pointed beyond its own cultural accommodations. Gender order is the same: a cultural waypoint we've rightly moved beyond." This is a *serious* argument (William Webb's redemptive-movement hermeneutic is its most careful form), and thoughtful, Bible-loving people hold it. Present it as its best defenders would.

Grant the premise (second click). Concede warmly what's true: the church *did* read the slavery texts badly for centuries; the correction came shamefully late; and that history should humble everyone in the room about our capacity to baptize our own culture. Don't rush past this; a concession genuinely made is what makes the class trust your analysis of where the argument fails.

The distinction: where each is grounded (third click). The analogy breaks at the point of *grounding*. Paul never grounds slavery in creation; there is no verse reading "for the master was formed first"; the master–slave relation is addressed as an existing social fact; the theological pressure Paul applies (Philemon: "no longer as a slave but as a beloved brother") runs *against* it. The assembly order, by contrast, Paul grounds in creation *twice*: "Adam was formed first, then Eve" (1 Tim 2:13) and "woman came from man… for man" (1 Cor 11:8–9). (Plant these now; they're next week's central texts.)

The banner (fourth click): "Cultural anchors drag. Creation anchors don't." An anchor set in shifting cultural soil drags when the culture moves, which is exactly why the church could, and should, move past slavery. An anchor set in creation doesn't.

The inversion (fifth click). So the analogy doesn't merely *fail*; it runs the *other way*. The very feature that made slavery movable (no creation grounding) is the feature the assembly texts conspicuously *have*. Same interpretive tool, opposite result. **Then close honestly:** this is an *argument*, and serious people still weigh the grounding differently; some read 1 Tim 2:13 as itself culturally shaped. We hold our conclusion with conviction *and* with the humility that this is contested exegesis, not a math proof. (That honesty is itself persuasive.)

Transition: to discussion.

Segments 5–6: Discussion and Close (45:00–57:00 · Slides 6–7)

Q1: "Why is 'God is clearly using them' not, by itself, a warrant for office? Where is it partly right?" The heart of the week, and it needs *both* halves. Where it goes wrong: it confuses *fruit* with *warrant*. God used Balaam's donkey, raised up pagan Cyrus as "my shepherd" (Isa 44:28), and spoke true prophecy through wicked Caiaphas (John 11:49–51): usefulness has never equaled appointment. But where it's *partly right* (be fair): fruit is a real *confirmation* of a calling already conferred: 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1 look for observable evidence in appointing elders. The error is making fruit the *source* of authority rather than a *confirmation* of authority conferred by the apostolic word. Draw that line carefully; it's the whole lesson in miniature.

Q2: "Where do WE feel the pull of results-based validation? Is it always wrong?" Get practical and self-implicating: *us*, not "those people out there." We all feel it: the church that's growing must be blessed; the ministry method that works must be right (Week 3's Moses-rock returns (it *worked* and was still wrong)). Steer toward nuance: results are legitimate *data* and God does confirm his work with fruit; data is not *authority*, and the moment "it works" overrides "what does the word say," we've re-run Eden's authority-swap. When is results-attention legitimate input, and when does it usurp the text? Model the distinction rather than resolving it flatly.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min). Next week is the harder, more personal question. Reading: 1 Timothy 2:1–15 (what Paul restricts, the reason in v.13, and (flag this hard) *what he does not say*) and 1 Corinthians 11:2–16 (note v.5: women pray and prophesy, so they arrive holding the *tension*, not a caricature). Preview Week 11, emphasizing the two words "*narrow*" and "the *full breadth* of women's ministry Scripture shows": reassure the class it will be careful and fair to both. Carry sentence: say it together. Close on 14:37, and dismiss on time and *warmly*, since the room may be tender, and a warm dismissal after contested material is itself pastoral care.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"Isn't 'the apostolic word' just code for 'whatever my tradition already believes'? Everyone claims Scripture." A fair challenge, and the answer is the whole course's method. "The apostolic word" means the *actual written text* of the New Testament, examined Berean-style (Week 5), not a tradition's summary of it, and not the teacher's certainty. The test is always "show me where it's written" (1 Cor 4:6, "do not go beyond what is written"). That's precisely *why* this class tests the teacher: the appeal is to the text every believer can open and check, not to an office or a party. When traditions differ, we reason from the text, not from the tradition.

"Are you saying the Spirit doesn't lead people directly anymore?" No, the Spirit genuinely indwells, gifts, convicts, and guides every believer (Rom 8, 1 Cor 12). The claim is narrower: the Spirit's leading of an individual never *contradicts or overrides* the Spirit's own written word, because it's the same Spirit (this was Week 5's guardrail against "God told me" trumping Scripture). Paul, full of the Spirit, still submits every prophet to "what I write" (14:37). Spirit and word together, never word-less spirit. A "leading" that pulls against the apostolic text is failing its own test.

"The early church had women prophets, deacons, and prominent leaders; doesn't that cut against you?" It does *not* cut against *this* week's thesis, and you should agree enthusiastically that they existed: Phoebe the *diakonos* (Rom 16:1), Philip's prophesying daughters (Acts 21:9), Priscilla, Junia, the many women Paul commends. Their reality is not in dispute. But notice: the early church affirmed women's *gifts* (prophecy especially) and still located governing *authority* in appointment; Origen concedes the gift and restricts the venue. That's exactly this week's gift/office distinction, not a counterexample to it. *Which* functions were open to whom is next week's question; that women ministered substantially is common ground.

"Doesn't this whole 'deposit handed down' idea lead to Roman Catholic apostolic succession?" It shares a starting instinct: authority is received, not invented; but lands differently. The New Testament locates the enduring deposit in the *apostolic teaching now inscribed in Scripture* ("the faith once for all entrusted," Jude 3; "the word of God," which endures), guarded by qualified elders in every congregation, not in an unbroken chain of ordinations conferring fresh authority. The baton that gets passed (2 Tim 2:2) is *the apostolic teaching itself*, entrusted to "faithful people competent to teach": the content, not a sacramental lineage. Different traditions draw this line differently, and that's legitimate study-ground; the point *this* week needs is only that authority is conferred by the apostolic word rather than generated by gifting or fruit.

"If someone is genuinely gifted to teach and clearly bearing fruit, isn't it quenching the Spirit to hold them back from a role?" This is the pastoral heart of Q1, so answer it gently. Gifting is real and God-given, and it should be *used*; the question is only *where* and *in what role*, which the apostolic word governs. Consider: a gifted teacher who submits their gift to biblical order is not being quenched; they're modeling the very obedience of faith the course is about (receiving conferred order rather than generating a rival warrant from their gift). The Corinthians were spectacularly gifted, and Paul still ordered their gatherings, not to quench, but because "God is not a God of disorder but of peace" (14:33). Order *frees* gifts to serve rather than compete. *Which* roles are governed how is next week; the principle here is that gift plus fruit is a reason to deploy someone wisely, not a warrant that overrides the text.

Prep Checklist

- [ ] Read 1 Corinthians 14:26–40 whole: the *gifts-chapter* context of v.37 is the whole argument
- [ ] Read 2 Timothy 2:2 and trace the four-generation relay; be ready to name each link
- [ ] Read enough of Webb's redemptive-movement argument (or a fair summary) to state it at full strength without a script
- [ ] Prepare your Balaam/Cyrus/Caiaphas examples for Q1 (God uses without appointing)
- [ ] Decide, in advance, how you'll invoke Week 5's "test the teacher" permission in the opening minute
- [ ] Reread the fairness mandate above the morning you teach: steelman, concede, distinguish structure from people
- [ ] Print/post next week's reading with both flags (v.13 reason / what Paul does NOT say; 11:5 women pray & prophesy)

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress the history table walk on slide 2 to the Montanist and Modern rows (they bracket the pattern); trim the four deposit texts on slide 4 to two (keep 1 Tim 2:7 and 2 Tim 2:2: appointment and relay); shorten the Origen/Hippolytus detail (name the gift/office distinction without the two figures). **Never cut:** the conferred/generated distinction (slide 2, the lecture's spine), the "who Paul names" observation on slide 3 (prophets and spiritual people), the trajectory objection *stated at full strength* on slide 5 (cutting the steelman destroys the fairness the week depends on), or the creation-grounding distinction that bridges to next week. If discussion must shrink, keep Q1: its fruit-vs-warrant distinction is the take-home, and it's the fairest, least combustible of the two questions.